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Interview Success Factors

Behavioral Interview questions determine how you will handle specific situations in a work environment. They often ask you to use your experience as an example and focus more on soft skills rather than technical aspects of the job. This allows a potential employer to understand how your past work experience has prepared you for future tasks and challenges. Surely you've been asked to answer a question like, "Tell me about a time you had a conflict with someone on your team?"

Instead of reflecting on your conflict resolution skills, you could end up waxing on about a former co-worker you disliked, and before you know it, the interviewer is put off. According to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, the number of job openings in the United States is at a record high of 11.5 million.

This bodes well for anyone looking to test the waters of what many are calling the hottest and most worker-friendly labor market in recent history. This is especially true for recent college graduates, the class of 2022. However, it's not all fun and games for potential new hires. In addition to adjusting their workplaces to accommodate the desires of workers, employers are also adjusting their interview process to become more particular about who they hire, making sure they find candidates that fit their culture and will hopefully stay with the company long term.

Experience

The most important thing to remember is that all of these questions are about your experiences. It will be helpful if you start your preparation by thinking about what stories you can draw from to answer these questions.

Job searchers need to plan ahead you could easily be asked a question you're not prepared for and if you try to wing it, things can get ugly. Hiring managers won't buy it, or worse, they may believe you intentionally avoid confrontation—neither of which will help you advance to the next interview round.

The best response is to name a weakness that only applies to specific situations, such as, "My impatience crops up when teammates don't deliver on their promises, as it relates to mission-critical assignments with tight deadlines. One of the easiest ways to handle behavioral interview questions is by sticking to the STAR method (Situation, Task, Action, Result).

Situation: Describe the situation where everything happened.

Task: Describe the task you had to complete to solve the problem/issue at hand.

Action: Explain what actions you took to complete the aforementioned task.

Results: Talk about the results of your actions and try to be as detailed as possible. How did your actions lead the company or organization to function better?

Most jobs require you to work as part of a team, so be prepared to talk about your experiences as a team member. You'll want a story that shows your ability to work with others under difficult circumstances. Think resolving team conflicts, dealing with project constraints, or motivating others.

Team Success

Teamwork questions are a great chance to point to your ability to collaborate, and your response should highlight your strengths in this area. It can be difficult to spin a conflict as a positive even if you feel you were not in the wrong. What's essential to remember is to not focus on the conflict itself in your reply but on the process of finding a solution.

When answering teamwork questions be sure your answer shows:

- You recognize all teams can have problems
- You can work with others even under challenging circumstances
- You are a good listener
- You react and act with care and consideration for your team

If the job requires you to work with outside parties such as clients, customers, or partnered businesses, prepare for these some of these questions. Employers will want to understand how you positively represented the company and how you overcame challenges to deliver exceptional customer service. Customer service questions will be your chance to prove you can handle difficult clients or customers. Show:

•The context of your interaction
•The type of customer or client you were dealing with
•The lesson you took from this experience

Time Slips By

Time management is important no matter what kind of work you do, so prepare to answer some of these questions. Most employers will want to hear how you balanced multiple things at once, prioritized, remained organized throughout, and got the job done by the deadline.

Take advantage of this opportunity to:

•Highlight any industry-specific tools you used to stay on track
•Emphasize how you communicated throughout the process
•IF it was necessary, that you can delegate efficiently and effectively

Communications

Like time management, most jobs will prioritize communication. You must be able to articulate your thoughts clearly and with respect. Most people will be able to come up with examples of communication, but the key here is to tell a story that highlights thoughtful preparation and logical thought process.

Communication questions are also a chance to highlight the different methods of communication you use and excel at. So if you're a fantastic writer, tell a story about a time you used written communication, if you're a great salesperson highlight your persuasiveness, and if you struggle with communication, don't shy away from it. Emphasize this isn't your natural strength and tell a story that shows you're working on improving in an area of weakness.

Adversity

Tough times don't last, but tough people do. Most people have had to overcome some sort of adversity in the workplace, so don't be afraid to get vulnerable, and be sure to emphasize how you successfully navigated that adversity. Even if the resolution was less than ideal, find a lesson you took from the experience and showcase how you turned a negative into a positive.

Use adaptability questions to talk about:

•How you set and stick to goals
•Specific methods of dealing with stress that are healthy and promote long-term success

Sometimes, interview questions can seem random or personal. A lot of these types of interview questions are attempts to learn more about what motivates you. Your response should ideally address values and motivations directly even if the question didn't explicitly ask about them.

Motivations

Motivation and values questions are a fantastic opportunity to:

•Highlight any special skills or passions you have that you haven't talked about yet
•Talk about what keeps you excited about your job
•Share where you see yourself in the future
•Describe how driven you are and what steps you'll take to get there

There are endless ways to answer behavioral interview questions. The most important things to remember are:

•Be honest
•Research potential questions ahead of time
•Write down rough outlines of stories you think would be good in response to questions
•Write down the skills you want to highlight within each story
•Practice, practice, practice

Stuffing your résumé and LinkedIn profile with generic buzzwords can be off-putting to potential employers; it's far worse when you recite them during an interview. Instead, practice describing your skills with terms a potential hiring manager can appreciate with anecdotes that demonstrate your qualifications and value.